

Mirror Image

Refiners Fire

Written by Levi Boswell

Fire enveloped my vision, the smoke choking my lungs with each breath, as my mother clenched my 12-year-old hand as we ran from a burning, flaming, ruined town only moments away. I could still hear the clashing of flesh and metal; screams of fear and horror filled the rest of the smoking wind.

“Where is father?” I asked, looking confused up at my mother, who was visibly distressed, with tears streaming from her face, as if she knew something I did not know. She only said the following words, looking down at me as we ran, “It’s going to be ok,” as we got further and further away.

That was the last day I ever saw my father, a mighty man and defender of truth and righteousness, protecting the people he swore to protect with his magic and blade, and I intended to follow in his footsteps and study the art of magic, little did I know that Owlea had much grander plans for me; and just how difficult that would be while the Anorath’s undead forces spread across the now-known country of Vrag, causing many kingdoms to bend the knee or die and become part of his rising army. During this time, my mother and I wondered which way we could go for safety; while I attended schools of the arcane and swordmanship, it was not long-lived, as it seemed wherever we would go, the forces of darkness followed, sweeping

through the lands. While I did my best to practice and study wherever I could, trying to find a solution to be able to defeat these undead forces, as killing them proved most challenging for conventional warfare. Fire seemed to work best though no one could find a way to get it hot enough to cause meaningful damage. It was not until that faithful day that a blessing from Owlea did dawn upon my mind like dew from heaven, while studying with others in the elven kingdom of Loyr, while under siege, awaiting allied forces from the northern human kingdom of Bellfast to give us aid. I was at my desk encrypting the enchantment to transmute two different materials into a healing remedy, when I received a thought which was most peculiar and to which, at this point of the remedy, I thought it would be able to break down the Icoyr by transmutation, breaking down into its more basic components of exelon, silicon, solution. As I prepared the changes given to me, and called upon my spirit, the candle light in the room flickered before a wind, a likely side effect, did blow the candle light out, and a faded blue glow began about to glow upon the script on the parchment and magic began to envelope from my hand over the bottle of Icoyr I had placed on the table as a test subject, as I watched incanting the spell, watching the medical herbs, my last Lylil glow and turn to dust as part of the material component the Icoyr began to become incredibly violent as it was surrounded by the magic. A surge and flash of magic flickered and glass shattered as the Icoyr exploded from the jar and immediately straight at me all I could do was watch before feeling it crawl forcefully down my throat and the feeling I can only describe as tearing out my insides I stumbled trying to cut the spirit connection to the spell but it was like another force was at play, I quickly grab my throat as if gasping for air, as my mother burst into the room hearing the distress, her face was just as in shock as I was, as she burst into the room the encrypting enhancement I made was amid disappearing as part of the innovation something which was did not happen with the countless other attempts. I then got what felt like a gut punch as I still was in an awful state of panic, which did cause me to tumble to the ground as I felt like I was about to throw up whatever was inside of me. I went to the window, opened it and began to throw up blood as my mother joined me,

giving me reassurance like I was but a little boy that unfortunate day, one of many. Was I cursed? What did I do to deserve such? I thought while throwing up on the side of the tower, 3 stories from the ground, all my other attempts failed but none were like this. I then looked up to see the rest of the fortress with a massive black mass and torch lights of columns of undead and living soldiers who were conscripted into Anorath's forces sitting just outside the main wall. They had been 3 weeks sieging the city. On the wall stood the armoured elven forces of Loyr protecting us from the siege. Then it all stopped, abruptly, and everything became clear as day. I looked up at my mother after recollecting myself, "well I think we both have had worse days," I said, trying to calm the situation. "She smiled, don't scare me like that, magic is dangerous, what did you even try to do this time that was different?" she asked, handing me a cloth to clean up the blood.

"I had a thought to change the enscript slightly to include targeting its molecular material rather than the Icoyr as a whole, to say the least something happened but what I don't know, exactly what, the thought was to change the invocation from destruction to healing by transmutation, perhaps that is the effect? Could you pass me that knife on my desk I use to trim the herbs?" I explained to her that my mother went and grabbed the knife knowing, I had done many healing magics in the past, as a simple cut was a good way to test if this new invocation was indeed healing magic. The air was tense as neither of us knew totally what had just happened, each having our own suspicions as to what Icoyr inside me was doing with the enchantment. As I held the knife over my pointer finger in anticipation, I looked at mom and then said, "Here we go," and made a small cut enough to draw blood, and almost immediately the wound closed, even before blood could escape. It still hurt, but the wound was healed in totality. "Well that's a result I wasn't expecting. I'm trying to destroy this stuff like every healer and cleric out there, and here it is healing me instead, at a rate unheard of unless by a high cleric of Owlea himself."

"What does this mean?" my mother asked,

“More testing is required. Do we have the material components for limb reattachment?” I said nervously. My mom, not surprisingly, responded as any mother would to someone about to attempt to cut off their own hand.

“Yes, but do you hear yourself!?” she said, concerned and worried as she thought she was about to lose her baby boy, likely because of what happened just moment ago, but a moment ago to an invocation gone wrong.

“Yes I do, but we got what we need if things go wrong, – ok here we go...” as I raised the knife, then a thud followed by the most held-back scream of pain I could do. Still, it quickly subsided as both my mother and I were amazed by what was taking place before our eyes, as my very flesh regrew before our own eyes, constructing the bone, then muscle and flesh. We both fell to the ground in awe. As I now had my hand back while also seeing my old hand disintegrate before our eyes, “Whoa...” I said to her in disbelief. “ya,” she responded, just as a voice began to cry out from the defences below as the thudding and crashing of rock and stone began to crash upon the fortress as the order of the attack began without warning.

“Quick were is the enscrip?” I asked my mom as I got up and sorted my desk where I was working.

“It disappeared glowing blue while you were casting the spell,” she responded.

“No, why, Owlea?” I muttered. My mother jumped in, “Owlea must have his reasons; he knows all. I guess we are to have faith.”

“I guess, but this new power is useless for me; it would be better equipped on an archmage or a general. I know only the basics of the school of evocation destruction magics in comparison to the healing magics, and my skills with the blade are adequate, as all men are taught, but I am no soldier yet.” I look to her, then to the forces struggling to hold against the forces of darkness,

using fire, the most potent magic we have found thus far, to fight, though the heat needs to be so intense that most magic fails to get hot enough, even oiled dipped blades only slow the zombies. "I can at least join them; perhaps I can save a few lives in the process." I look to her. She looks back at me as a mother would, "If it be Owleas will, I will give my only son as an offering to stop the forces of darkness... I love you, Évrán. You will always be mine. May Owlea protect you. I'll be here to help in whatever way a mother can," she said, giving me a hug, tears shown upon both our faces. A thunderous boom occurred as a rock crashed into the tower, causing dust and trembling to occur as we got our footing, we nodded, as we have been in similar situations dozens of times by now. I put on my tattered school robe, cleaned but stained and torn, with a blue and white trim, grabbed my book of spells and ran down the stairs of the towered attic we were living in at the time. My mother followed until we got to the main street where we separated ways, I could here cry of "they broke through the gate!" and "to the Gate Protect the Citizens!", as another thundering boom occurred above me, as a rock crashed into a stone building, causing it to collapse, the falling rubble to were I was, if I did not run out of the way, those stones would have crushed me were I stood. The chaos felt that day was palpable; as I made my way down to the front gate to see a brutal clash between the Loyr elven forces clashing with the undead, weapons lit a flame I came up to one of the captains who I recognized a day prior in the market,

"Captiain, I have come to give you aid!" I shouted trying to have my voice reach him over the sound and roar of combat.

"Evran?! Whats a Sage doing on the battlefield, you should stay back and tend the wounded." he responded turning to me and putting his hand on my shoulder.

"I understand your concern sir, but I have just completed an experimental magic and this seemed like the most prime opportunity to test its potential. Sir." I concluded. He looked at me

with a stern look like a concerned father, as a stray arrow threaded through the crowd and directly hitting me in the shoulder with enough force to knock me down to the ground as I dropped my book. But before the captain could reach down, he saw me slowly get up grasping the arrow and then wrench the arrow out from my flesh and that the gushing wound quickly had already stopped bleeding. He was in shock, as I grabbed my book and stood by up. "Hand me a blade," I said to him. He was still in shock, unsheathed his short sword and handed it to me. "Thanks, let's hope this magic lasts." I then ran into the fray alongside the armoured in plate mail elven soldiers with nothing but a sword and half baked book of spells.

It was difficult to move as holding the gate we were packed shoulder to shoulder shoving spears and pikes at each other while anything that got past had to deal with the blade, though I quickly realized just how bad the situation was when I had a clean cut to one of the zombies the smell of which was horrendous causing me to gag in utter horror. I came down as hard as I could upon the zombie's head cutting it clean off, though the zombie was completely unphased and quickly much faster than I thought the thing could move slashed with a sword of its own before I could make a defense. A soldier on my left noticed just in time and slammed me aside causing the blow to glance off his armour. "Who let a mage into front line, and a kid no less?!" he angrily staired, shouting out to his mates. Another roared back one foot on a zombie's chest holding a sword down its throat, "captain let him in, apparently testing something!" the other shouted. I got my footing, realizing that the zombie had not regrown its head like my hand to note that what ever Owlea inspired me to do it was different, "this isn't going to work, I wonder if there is anything in here that will help, as I started looking through the book of spells I had made myself, quickly running through the pages as another pike broke through the lines, and I being oblivious took the hit directly to the gut, I spat out blood onto a page of the book as the pike released and stuttered, "MAN DOWN!" one of the soldiers said as I collapsed from pain, "well so much for the test." but before any of his mates could join in on their morbid humour I stood up with a new

hole in my robe blood stained but my wound healed completely. "Holy mother of Owlea, what magic is that!" One soldier, astonished, glanced not before taking a pike to the chest, though the damage was minimal because of the armour. "Don't care as long as we have it on our side for a change. The fire magics are simply only slowing these things and or not hot enough to do real damage, you basically have to cut each zombie arms and legs off!" another soldier shouted. And they were right, with enough heat you could kill a zombie, but it was in the realm of 2000 plus degrees, which most weapons only got to a measly 300-600, and some magic up to 1500, which is close, often heating an iron or steel blade though causes the blade to dull and warp very quickly in battle, though they don't heat further because the metals were already at their melting points. I kept looking trying to find something but nothing not one spell in my book could be cast quickly enough as most incantations can be upto 10 minutes or longer in some case with the shortest being a minute long. If only there were a way to quickly hack together a spell fast enough for the effect to work. My mind began to rack me with the torment of this power, and being useless to do anything as I quickly was running out of pages of spells in my collection. I slumped to my knees, and occasionally get scraped by a spear, arrow, or debris from the enemy, painful but not to the depths of despair which I felt, this new power that I felt like anyone, anyone other than me could have used it better and more fully then I, but before I could wallow in my pity, Anorath's forces broke through the line which I was part of and I found myself surrounded by the enemy as allied forces began to fall dead before my eyes then raised; as zombies would hover over there prey then the lcoyr would pass from the mouth of the zombie into the mouth of the dead as its bones contorted and blood began to shoot from every oraphus. At this point, two spears had pinned me to the ground while I knelt as I watched the creation of a new zombies before my eyes. While I was being held in place, one of the newer zombies came over to perform the same process upon me. In one last attempt I began to utter a basic heat metal invocation I had memorized for heating metal to use in smithing. As the zombie got closer, I could still smell the horrific smell of the dead. It bent unnaturally low and began to grow extra

wide on its mouth. I was about to become one of them. The black lcoyr liquid, like a sick tounge slithered out and toward my mouth at which point I reached up with my right hand, invocation ready and grabbed it finishing the casting of the spell and putting the heat to the max, well over 4000, disregarding my own hand as I reeled in pain as the heat turned the tongue rock solid, and then shattered into dust. Seeing the effectiveness i quick struck with my hand the zombie and were ever I hit it the fletch would melt and the lcoyr turned to dust, what ever wasn't hot enough got the flesh to begin to burn, and all that was left was a black web with a orange hot solid image of hot metal of the once zombiefied humaiod when the flesh stopped burning. The two zombies pinning me to the ground stepped back, but a moment later I quickly grabbed one of the spears with my new heat metal evocation spell, causing the spear's wooden shaft to disintegrate as I spun around to do the same on the other side of my positioned myself kicking a zombie holding the now borken spear along the way and breaking free, as I completed a second cast for my other hand, realling in pain; as I stood with two black orange hot palms in torn blood soaked and singed blue and white stained robes surrounded but zombies armed to the teeth, my ribbon holding my hair in place falling off and letting my long silver lock flow in the wind around facing the darkend rotten corpses around me; with the main gate busted and broken in the background with nothing but a seas worth of opponents waiting to be let in, just has the horns of allied forces from the kindom of Bellfast arrived to the north.

"Looks like I am on gate duty," I said, smirking, heart racing with adrenaline, as I kept the spell burning my nerve endings in my hand so I don't feel the pain enough to focus, even though I could feel my hands being repaired at the same time, an odd feeling at best to describe. I then lashed out grabbing on of the zombies heads with on of my hands causing it to burst into flames as I shoved it away, to only get a sword to the back, reeling in pain, I quick spun around to place my hand on the metal breastplate it was wearing to only have the metal quickly begin to melt at which point my hand reached the target and the zombie burst into flames. Thus, the battle

ensued over the course of what felt like forever, exhausted, but the enemy forces retreated not much longer after Belfast arrived. I found myself standing at the gate when the captain and his forces returned to see me exhausted standing with blackened and orange hot palms shirtless as my robes were so destroyed that they became part of the tunic, as I stood unscathed surrounded by black metallic statues of amalgamated metal of the inner workings of the humanoid body, many of which began to crumble to dust; my long silver hair flowing in the wind with the gate in the center piece background. "In Owlea's name, what have we been blessed with?" the captain said, dumbfounded. Along with the rest, they all thought I was assumed dead. It was the first time since this evil began that any man could go toe to toe with the undead, let alone hold out alone against an entire column of them. That was not the end of the war; it took 5 more years before Anorath was defeated. A fellowship emerged between men, elves, dwarves, and changlings; I was one of them who was summoned to join them. They were the brightest and the best in all the realm; together we sought out and searched for Anorath's lair and eventually slew him in the peaks of the Hiyr'crest Mountainside. Along that journey, I found the limitations of my regeneration, and if not for one of my companions, Laura'Loyran of Loyr, lady luck herself, I would have perished. With Anorath defeated, all his forces of undead became dead once more, and his empire scattered, though that is a story I have written in my other book.